The engineer had played the first disk on his stack of records—the Mills Brothers singing “Minnie the Moocher’s Wedding Day.”

I gained one love, but lost another in Des Moines. It was there I first heard the words, “Nothing is so good for the inside of a man as the outside of a horse.”

I think I’d probably first discovered an affinity for horses when I was still lifeguarding at Lowell Park. There was a lodge at the park run by a Danish immigrant who owned a big gray horse and he occasionally rode it down to the bath house; a couple of times, when there weren’t any swimmers on the beach, he let me ride it. I didn’t know it then, but he was introducing me to one of the joys of my life. In Des Moines, I made some friends who liked to ride and they began inviting me, when we all had a free afternoon, to go to a local stable and rent horses for an hour or so and I enjoyed it very much.

Then, another announcer at WHO, a reserve officer in the army cavalry, told me the Fourteenth Cavalry Regiment based at Fort Des Moines offered young men a chance to obtain a reserve commission through what the War Department called the Citizens Military Training Program. I didn’t have a burning desire to be an army officer—I still thought we’d fought the war to end all wars—but it was a deal too good to turn down: In exchange for enlisting in the reserve, the army offered training by some of the best cavalrymen in the country and unlimited use of army horses, all free. Ever since I’d become addicted to Saturday matinees, I’d had an affection for those scenes when a troop of cavalrymen in blue tunics and gold braid, flags raised and bugles blowing, raced across the prairie to rescue beleaguered pioneers.

In Des Moines, I transformed some of the childhood fantasies into reality and discovered a lifelong love for horses and riding. I just fell in love with riding and I began to